
The London Free Press

Serving London, Ontario Since 1849

LONDON, ONTARIO · COMMUNITY VOICES · PERSONAL HISTORY



Irene Gargantini Strybosch

From Milan to London: A Short Autobiography

Professor Emeritus, Western University · IEEE Life Member · Author of Nine Novels

By Irene Gargantini Strybosch

A CHILD IN WARTIME ITALY

I was born in 1934, in Milan, Italy. The thirties were a decade of economic crises and much political turmoil. Hitler had seized power in '33, the civil war in Spain had broken out in '36 and Mussolini was keeping a tight hold on Italy. My father, an engineer with the railroads, was transferred from Milan to Bologna just because of his 'unacceptable' habit of telling jokes about the regime.

A happy kid in perpetual motion, I was always ready to play and learn. I had loving parents, a grandmother who knew an incredible number of funny fairytales, and an aunt with whom my sister and I played all sorts of games. The family lived in grandmother's two-storey house, with a nice little garden, a fig tree, grape vines and a large terrace sheltered by a big wisteria.

THE BOMBING OF MILAN

On October 12th 1942, Milan suffered its first bombardment by the British Air Force. Our only neighbour, a big chemical company, had been militarized to produce explosives, so our entire block became one of the enemy's major targets. An incendiary bomb destroyed part of our house, but nobody got hurt.

I wandered around, trying to figure out what had happened. Our room was no more — its beds, bookcase, armoire, and toys all gone. I heard my mother say, "We have to think about the girls. We should go buy them some underwear."

I remember thinking: "Grown-ups don't have any sense of what's important. There are no more dolls, no more toys. I can't even find my teddy bear. And what do they think about? Underwear!" That day will be etched in my memory forever.

A few weeks later we moved to the country. Times were tough, and became tougher as the war lengthened. There was little food, no soap, only a few pieces of wood to keep the cooking stove going. Finally, on April 25th, 1945, the hostilities ceased.

A CAREER IN COMPUTING

After high school I obtained a degree in Physics from the University of Milan, my thesis on the trajectory of electrons accelerated by a synchrotron. Two years before, the same university had graduated Riccardo Giacconi, the future Nobel laureate in Cosmic X-ray Sources.

I learned the rudiments of programming from such notables as Drs. Luigi Dadda, Lorenzo Lunelli and Guido Bortone, and got to work on one of the very first computers, the CRC 152A, made by the Computer Research Corporation — a gift of the Americans to our polytechnic institute.

In 1958 I joined The European Atomic Energy Community (Euratom). To accelerate the computing process I developed rational approximations for the evaluation of neutron flux and efficient methods to estimate heat dispersion in nuclear bars — requiring fewer operations and making calculations faster.

In 1965 I was offered a position with the IBM Research Laboratory in Rüschlikon, Switzerland. One day, perusing the Communications of the ACM, my eyes focused on an announcement: The University of Western Ontario was establishing the first Canadian undergraduate programme in computer science, headed by Dr. John F. Hart.

ARRIVING IN LONDON

I arrived in London, Ontario on July 10th 1968. The young department had only a handful of teaching staff, but almost immediately attracted a huge number of interested students. After a year I was offered the position of associate professor. With some regret, I resigned from IBM and decided to stay.

The faculty of science saw computers mainly as 'toys' and our research as 'playing games.' They seemed to have no vision of the new discipline's future. Their short-sightedness encompassed sexism where female faculty were concerned — and being an immigrant compounded my problem even further.

"I was the first woman in Canada to ever hold the chair of a computer science department."

Despite such obstacles, I remained focused. I compiled and introduced undergraduate courses on Analysis of Algorithms, Computer Arithmetic and Computer Graphics. The work with Doctor Uldis Bite produced one of the first software packages in the country for the visualization of CT scans. I published about one hundred scientific papers, among which was a seminal paper on Circular Arithmetic that over the years had thousands of follow-ups.

A HISTORIC APPOINTMENT

In 1986 I was appointed Chair of the Department of Computer Science — the first woman in Canada to ever hold the chair of a computer science department. At a reception held by the president, Dr. George Petersen, as my husband and I

entered the door the president rushed to him and said, “What a pleasure it is to meet the chair of the Computer Science Department!” My husband stood there, amused for a moment, then pointed at me and replied: “It’s her, not me!”

I held that post from 1986 to 1991, and felt proud of bringing the department to a new research level. Recognition came mostly from outside academia: two awards from NSERC and two from the IBM Centre for Advanced Studies.

LIFE & FAMILY

A few years after my tough landing in Canada, I met my husband, Martin Gerardus Strybosch, who helped me appreciate all the possibilities this country offers. He gave me a family — some of his five children grew close to me, and a few years later I enjoyed, with him, the birth of ten grandchildren. Babysitting was often the highlight of my weekends.

My Martin died in 2007, leaving big holes in the emotional and physical aspects of my life. Retired since the year 2000, I reverted to the passion of my youth — writing fiction. I enjoyed enormously the creative process of forging a story, populating it with different, often contrasting characters.

AWARDS & PUBLICATIONS

The Blackpox Threat *First place, 2012*
Five Star Dragonfly Award; Finalist, 2011
National Indie Excellence Award

The Loves and Tribulations of Detective Stephen Carlton *Silver Medal, 2015*
Global Ebook Awards

The Woman in Black *Second place, 2015*
Five Star Dragonfly Award

Fleeting Visions *Included in the 2016*
Timeless Anthologies, The Reader’s Guild

“Going back to Italy is always a joyful interlude, but I am extremely grateful for all that this country has offered me, and still offers to me.”

*Professor Emeritus, Western University · London,
Ontario · IEEE Life Member*